



HEISTS AND THE RING

LORE SUPPLEMENT

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THE RING

This place runs foul with thieves, cutthroats, and loudmouths. I am likely the only one here that would not betray you for coin.

--Adiyah, "Rogue Harbour" (male version) (POE I)

The Ring operates outside whatever semblance of the 'law' remains out here. But lawlessness does not exclude civility, and does not need to create chaos. If someone is intent on taking what is not theirs, better to have a professional handle it and avoid unnecessary violence and confusion.

The Ring is contracted by those who seek a solution to the... misallocation of resources. We assign members based on the needs of the job, and we take a small cut. Everyone wins, other than the target of our work.

--Kurai, "The Ring" (POE I)

The Ring operates based on favours. Markers allow us to track those favours, and to ensure no one is taking advantage of, or being taken advantage of, by any other Ring member. They are also how you got here. You'll excuse me if that seemed obvious. At times I must deal with people whose talents are... not intellectual in nature.

--Kurai, "Markers" (POE I)

... Take a marker in your hand. Speak these words into your mind: The Ring binds us all, and to all within I shall do no harm. ...

--Kurai, "Rogue Marker" (POE I)

What is valuable to you or I may not be valuable to the Boss or Faustus. Where you see a worthless trinket, another may see a precious heirloom, or the final piece in a life-long collection. Contracts allow our clients to hire the Ring to pursue goods that hold no objective value on the client's behalf. Sometimes that value comes from knowing the original owner no longer has it.

The Ring makes few moral judgements on what it is hired to obtain. So long as it is not breathing and it is not liable to put the entire Ring at risk, we will not turn a contract down. And neither should you.

--Kurai, "Contracts" (POE I)

Though Contracts allow the Ring to keep spinning, we are skilled professionals, and skilled professionals wish to test the limits of their skills. The Ring has obtained the layouts of locations known to hold objects of great value. Naturally, these locations are heavily protected and patrolled, and to pull off a job in such a location requires a team.

The Boss is happy to provide blueprints for these highly secure locations and access to the skills and resources needed to strip such a location bare... for a price. Complete contracts, earn markers, and you will be able to utilise those services.

--Kurai, "Blueprints" (POE I)

Dominus was a terrible human being, but the Ring owes a great debt to him. Without his overzealous exilings, the Ring would not have a rich pool of talent to draw upon. The Boss himself learned a great deal about the power of anonymity and mythos from Dominus. Lessons he employs today.

--Kurai, "Dominus" (POE I)

One of my men followed a never-do-well recently. I believe there's a cache of stolen goods in this map. The criminals must have their own map device technology, but at least they're only using it for illicit exchanges. The cache is up for grabs, if you can find it.

--Kirac, on a Heist mission (POE I)

THE BOSS

... The Boss...rules through deception, obfuscation, and manipulation. However, if he agrees to do something, he will do it. That in itself is a form of honour which I can respect. ...

--Adiyah, "The Boss" (POE I)

Ah, the Boss. The big man. The man of a thousand faces, or no face, depending on who you ask. He's cultivated quite the reputation, hmm?

I fancy myself a connoisseur of the truth, and I have yet to hear a story about the Boss that has the wondrous ring to it that only true stories have. But...

Well, I have certain connections, and those connections have certain connections who have turned up some very striking truths about this mysterious figure.

I'm not about to run my mouth to a thief, but let me tell you, those definitely-not-true stories you keep hearing? The truth is even stranger.

--Faustus, "The Boss" (POE I)

Interesting man. Very interesting indeed. Hairless as the day he came into this world. No need for a man of my trade, you see. Yet, bald as he may be, he knows the value of a good barber.

No one here knows much about the Boss's past, except maybe Kurai, and she won't tell you much, not even for a mountain of markers. Loyalty is the most valuable currency, and she and the Boss have a lifetime supply.

I tried to find out what I could. Conflicting tales of a smuggler kingpin, a Theopolan aristocrat, and, strange enough, a retired arena champion. Then Kurai told me to stop sniffing around, else I end up like the last barber. Or maybe she said I'd end up *the* last barber. Either way, I value my life and my work more than I value gossiping about an old, bald, gladiatorial smuggler.

--Whakano, "The Boss" (POE I)

Heard the Boss got his start as a stable boy in the Grand Arena. Used to feed and care for the chariot horses. That was his first job, and it led to his first ... err, 'job'.

Apparently, someone asked him to slip something into the feed of the Octavius family's finest stallion, greatly favoured to win the race. Paid him a week's worth of his normal wages. Boss figured it was some sort of poison. So he watched the man place a bet, and poisoned that horse as well. Neither died, but neither won, and the Boss, betting his wages on a horse he knew to be fit as a gladiator, took home a killing.

'Course, that was also his last day of gainful employment at the arena. The man stalked those stables for months trying to find him.

--Tibbs, "The Boss" (POE I)

... It just so happens that the Boss, cultural elite that he is, saw me in a few shows. He must have noticed my ability to fully embody any role, to become not just the character, but the person. I'm told he was a practitioner of the performing arts himself, in his youth. Obviously, he has a keen eye for talent. ...

--Gianna, "The Boss" (POE I)

A man of style, the Boss. A thief of course wants to be rich and live a life of luxury, but once you hit a certain point of wealth, I imagine you might be motivated by other things.

Apparently, the Boss was living very comfortably indeed, but felt the need to challenge himself. He entered the First Bank of Theopolis in the middle of the day, entered the vault, and just started... movin' stuff around. Octavius family fortunes into the Maxius deposit box, Avarius riches split across every small safe, each of which he popped open as if there weren't even a lock on 'em. Mixing all the money up like it were caught in the tides. Then he goes and finds the records of deposits and withdrawals, and sets 'em on fire. Walks out like nothing happened.

Well, of course the bank puts the fire out, but the records are gone. So they notify all the big customers, telling them to come in with their copy of the deposit slips... and wouldn't you know it, they're gone too.

No bloody idea how he pulled it off. 'Course, the bank and all the clients will deny it ever happened. Be foolish not to.

--Karst, "The Boss" (POE I)

The Boss is private to the point of paranoia. I've never visited his home, but I've heard he has some very particular requests of his guests. No boots. No cloaks or coats. No hats. No slacks. No dresses. Undergarments are strongly discouraged. You're given a robe for privacy. It has no sleeves. You're never to enter his kitchen or approach him from behind or from the side. Or above. Absolutely never above. No mention of approaching him from below, but I've also heard he lives underground, so that would be quite a task.

--Tullina, "The Boss" (POE I)

Tibbs: ... How's the Boss doing?

Kurai: Busy. Stressed. Worried for the safety of those in his care.

Tibbs: He's a good man.

Kurai: The best.

--Kurai & Tibbs, "Banter" (POE I)



KARST, THE LOCKPICK

I'm Karst. Rather than waste my youth readin', I put that time to better use. Now I can pick just about any lock you're likely to come across.

--Karst, "Introduction" (POE I)

... Karst is not as tough as he believes, but the Boss has never seen another Lockpick as talented.

--Kurai, "Your First Job" (POE I)

STOLEN LOCKPICKS

Got my contract, do ya? Ran with some low-life criminal scum in the back alleys of Oriath in my younger days. Real good blokes. Loyal to the last, or so I thought. Right before I was exiled, they beat me half to death and took off with my finest lock picks. If I'd had 'em when the Law came for me, I probably wouldn't be here, so in a sense, I 'spose I should be thankful, eh?

Well I'm not. I want those picks back, and I spent a lot of markers to find out where they went. Now I know, and you're gonna help me get 'em.

--Karst, "Stolen Lockpicks" (POE I)

They were me granddaddy's. Could break into any house as quick and silent as a Cardinal's fart.

--Karst's Lockpicks (POE I)

Strange. I thought having these picks back would make me feel whole again, but...

Well, it's not your problem, rookie. Not yet.

--Karst, "Stolen Lockpicks" (POE I)

KARST'S REVENGE

Been good having my old picks back. Real good. Just not good enough. It's like there's a lock inside me, and not even my beautiful antique picks can open it. But I been thinkin' about it long and hard, and I reckon I know what might.

Revenge.

One of me old crew recently got out of the game. Livin' a life of luxury now while everyone around him is suffering and strugglin' just to survive. That should've been my life, but he took it from me when he took my picks. I want to send him, and the rest of my old crew, a message. So, rather than take something, we're going to leave something. Something that'll put the fear of Sin into the lot of 'em.

--Karst, "Karst's Revenge" (POE I)

Bet you're wondering what happens now, eh? Interesting little toxin we left. Slowly fills the air, then the lungs. Never leaves the body. Just keeps building up. First you start feeling light headed. Then you start hearing things, start seeing things. Start getting paranoid. A day or two later, you feel tingly. The tingling turns to pain, and the pain keeps building until your heart just stops beating.

I'd wash your hands if I was you.

--Karst, "Karst's Revenge" (POE I)

CREDIT WHERE CREDIT'S DUE

Word of our last job has started gettin' round. Unfortunately, all the credit is goin' to an old rival of ours. That don't sit right with me. It's one thing to steal a man's property, but to steal a man's hard work? No, I ain't gonna let that stand.

So we're going to leave a little present at my ol' rival's abode. One of my prized lockpicks, dipped in the very same toxin."

--Karst, "Credit Where Credit's Due" (POE I)

You know what, rookie? I do believe I feel whole again. It's only a matter of time 'til that old rival of mine suffers the same fate as my traitorous crewmate. With both the bastards dead, and my pick the only common thread, the message is crystal clear:

Don't steal from a thief.

--Karst, "Credit Where Credit's Due" (POE I)



HUCK, THE SOLDIER

Sir! Sorry, old habit. You'll get used to it. Blackguard training did a number on me. I'm Huck. Served in the Oriath 3rd for five years. Dishonourably discharged, though I consider that an honour.

My time with the Blackguards put a lot of things in perspective, least once I had some distance from them. What we do here might be illegal, but that don't make it wrong.

You need something -- anything -- you come to me, yeah? We're family now. Family look out for each other.

--Huck, "Introduction" (POE I)

Haven't actually met him myself. Been dealing mostly with lady Kurai. Bit like the old days, really. Orders come down the chain and stop when they hit the right pair of ears.

I'm eager to meet him though. Owe him my life. Had some very dark days after I got discharged. Not a lot of people want to hire veterans, especially when they leave the service under less-than-ideal circumstances. But the Boss secured me a place to live, and gave me a steady income and work to keep me busy.

--Huck, "The Boss" (POE I)

Huck: Lady Kurai.

Kurai: Glad you could join us, Huck. We've got a job in the works.

Huck: I see! Well, I'm happy to help in any way I can.

Kurai: I thought you might be. Before we set off, the Boss wanted me to check in with you.

Huck: Oh?

Kurai: How are you feeling? Mentally.

Huck: Still a bit... uneven. Still getting angry over little things.

Kurai: I understand. The Boss is intent on giving you the support you need, but realise that if you harm any members again, you will be asked to leave.

Huck: Understood. And... Sorry.

--Huck & Kurai, "Banter" (POE I)

Kurai: Huck, thank you for coming.

Huck: No worries, my lady.

Kurai: Whakano informs me you have been looking for old acquaintances.

Huck: Yeah. Not looking to get back into the unit or anything, don't worry. Just miss a few people.

Kurai: I see. In that case, the Boss will cover the costs of your search.

Huck: Oh, no, he doesn't have to do that.

Kurai: He wants to.

Huck: Thank you, lady Kurai.

--Kurai & Huck, "Banter" (POE I)

ENOCH'S WHEREABOUTS

Ah, my contract. Took it out not long after joining the Ring to track down a mate of mine. Man named Enoch. Not easy making friends at my age, but active duty has a way of forging near-unbreakable bonds. Enoch and I got real close. Might as well've been brothers. Right before I got discharged, Enoch was called up to a special unit we'd heard rumours about. A group under the direction of Piety, of all people. Supposedly some elite strike force, but no one personally knew anyone who was a part of it. 'Til Enoch, that is.

After I started working for the Boss, I asked Whakano to find Enoch. Thought he might be a good fit. But Whakano found no traces. I want to break into the Blackguard Records and find out where he's deployed.

--Huck, "Enoch's Whereabouts" (POE I)

Let's see... Good. Enoch's file is in here. Let's go.

--Huck, during contract (POE I)

Gods damn them. Piety, Dominus, Gravicius, the whole lot of 'em. They moved Enoch into an 'Unspecified Research' unit. Dead a month later, the cause listed as 'Severe reaction to subdermal augmentations'. They tried to turn him into a gods-damned gemling, and killed him in the process. Oh, Enoch. I'm so sorry, mate.

I appreciate the backup, Exile. I need a bit of time to sort my emotions out, but I reckon I'll have more work for you soon enough.

--Huck, "Enoch's Whereabouts" (POE I)

ENOCH'S REMAINS

Not long after we found Enoch's file, Whakano informed me that he'd found Enoch's family, and that even they had no idea where he was. They assumed he was still on duty.

Can you believe that? The bloody Templars had the gall to massacre Enoch and not even tell his family. That just don't sit right with me.

His records don't list a final resting place, but I know that most blackguards who died on duty were cremated and put to rest in the tunnels beneath the city. It's a long-shot, but maybe we can find some trace of Enoch, to give his parents peace.

--Huck, "Enoch's Remains" (POE I)

Look at me now, Captain Arturo!

Victory! Didn't have many of those in my unit!

--Huck, "Banter 2 & 3" (POE I)

Enoch was the sort of man who'd starve to make sure you had something to eat. The sort of man whose oath to protect and preserve informed everything he did. He deserved far better than he got, and we can do nothing for him now. But with his service records and his tags, we can at least let his mum and dad know what happened.

Don't worry, Exile. I'll handle this messy part. You've done more than enough. Thank you.

--Huck, "Enoch's Remains" (POE I)



TIBBS, THE GIANT

Round here, people call me Tibbs. Not the quietest little sneak, and I'm not exactly nimble with these big sausage fingers, but if you find yourself on the wrong side of something heavy, you'll wish you thought to hire me.

--Tibbs, "Introduction" (POE I)

FINDING OPAL

Ah, my contract! A man of my build gets a lot of attention. By the time I was thirteen, I was taller than most adults. By my next birthday I was invited to join a little circus of sorts as the strongman. That's where I met Tullina, by the way.

One day, someone left a baby girl, named Opal, for the troupe leader. She had bright red eyes, but the most pale skin and whitest hair I'd ever seen. She became a sort of daughter of the whole troupe. We took turns looking after her.

By the time she was about seven, I'd grown quite attached to her, and she to me. The hardest part of being exiled is not knowing what has happened to her. So I want to find out. I know the troupe is disbanded, so I just want to make sure she's found a good home.

--Tibbs, "Finding Opal" (POE I)

Loved her like she was my own daughter. I just want to know she's safe.

--Census Records (POE I)

Always get butterflies before a job...

Come on, Gil. You've got this. Easy as. Eeeaaasy as.

--Tibbs, "Banter 1 & 4" (POE I)

Well, it ain't great news. Templar took an interest in her because of her unique traits, but she dropped off the map before they could get her. Good instincts.

I have a hunch that she might've found some of the old troupe members. I'll see what Whakano can dig up.

--Tibbs, "Finding Opal" (POE I)

OPAL'S JEWELS

Got an update on Opal! She's living on the fringes with some of the old troupe, like I thought. Tough people to track down, but at least I know she's safe.

I want to keep it that way. I want to make sure she doesn't need to put herself at risk to work or eat, so we're going to do what is, essentially, the opposite of a bank robbery. We're breaking in to leave enough wealth for her to live safely out of harm's way in a vault under a pseudonym.

--Tibbs, "Opal's Jewels" (POE I)

Damn near everything I've earned. Worth every little bit.

--Tibbs' Wealth (POE I)

I know I'm a lot poorer than I was a few days ago, but I feel like I've done some real good. Opal's a smart kid. She'll put that money to good use. Better than I would've anyway.

Thanks, Exile. Really.

--Tibbs, "Opal's Jewels" (POE I)



TULLINA, THE CATBURGLAR

I'm Tullina. Not Tully, not Lina, not Lin, not even Tee. Tullina, got it? Good. If you know when to speak and know when to keep your mouth shut, we'll get on just fine. I'm here to make bank, not friends, and I'm very good at what I do.

--Tullina, "Introduction" (POE I)

THE WEDDING DRESS

Look, as a rule I don't ask for help. I don't need someone getting involved in my business and messing everything up. Unfortunately, I must now break that rule. I need... I-... Ugh. Why is this so hard? Ineedyourhelp. There. I said it.

Before I was exiled, I was romantically involved with a man from a very good family. We kept it secret while he tested the waters with his mother and father -- it's not exactly ideal for the nobility to be fraternising with the 'uncouth', as they say. Less than a week before I was heaved overboard and my exile began in earnest, he proposed.

I know it's crazy, and I know it's almost certainly impossible, but I want so desperately to marry that man. Just taking his name would wash clean my past, and I know I could find happiness.

So I need a dress. When Merveil and Daresso wed, they held a most elaborate ceremony. Merveil was said to be the most beautiful visage ever to walk down the Basilica aisle. It took six people to carry the train on her dress. I want that dress. I need that dress. My beloved deserves to see me in that dress. So you're going to help me get it, got it?

--Tullina, "The Wedding Dress" (POE I)

Let's just hope she wasn't wearing it when she wandered into the sea!

--Merveil's Wedding Dress (POE I)

The Lady Merveil's dress is even more beautiful than I'd imagined. It's held up well over the years, and fits nearly perfectly.

I appreciate your help on this matter. I'll add you to our invitees. No plus-ones.

--Tullina, "The Wedding Dress" (POE I)

DISENGAGEMENT

I'm fine. Sorry, I mean, hello. But, really, I'm fine. I don't need your help.

...Wait.

I... I do need your help. It's time to face reality. The wedding's off. Given our wildly different lifestyles, it no longer seems possible for my fiancé and I to live happily ever after. Whakano has kept abreast of his movements, and, though he has remained faithful, he is... unhappy. I don't think it's because they have locked him up in an attempt to draw me out, but it couldn't have helped. I miss him dearly, and he misses me, but we cannot meet in person without jeopardising his safety or my freedom. He needs to move on, and so do I.

I want to return our engagement ring. He'll understand. I cannot bear to do it myself, hence the contract.

...Please?

--Tullina, "Disengagement" (POE I)

It isn't fair to either of us to keep chasing this dream.

--Tullina's Engagement Ring (POE I)

Tullina sent you, didn't she? ...Oh no.

Tell her I understand, and I'm sorry.

--Julius Farrow, during contract (POE I)

So... it's done. We're done. I feel... absolutely awful, actually. But I also feel lighter. He will no doubt grieve for a long time, and will, of course, never find another woman that meets the lofty bar I set, but he will meet someone eventually. He will fall in love. He will propose to her. She will be delighted. They will marry and start a family, and they will have their happy ending. It was the right thing to do, for both of us.

Thank you for your help, and your discretion. I'm keeping that dress, by the way. Lady Merveil's? That's mine now.

--Tullina, "Disengagement" (POE I)



NILES, THE INTERROGATOR

The name's Niles. I'm the resident thought extractor. Not got much to say to you just yet. Still uncertain whether I interrogated you before the Templars exiled you. Would put us quite at odds, wouldn't it? But I interrogated so many, I hardly remember their faces anymore. If I don't remember you, it probably means you broke easily...

--Niles, "Introduction" (POE I)

I know a thing or two about figureheads using mystery to evoke faith. It's how they deceive the masses, you see. One can never find fault with a god if one never meets him! Who, then, spreads all these tales? A Karui told me that Tukohama cut Kitava's face with a tooth. I asked him, how do you know about it if you weren't there for it? So, he stabbed me.

That's what you'll get if you start asking around about the Boss. A stabbing. Only - unlike Karui - this knife won't come from the front.

--Niles, "The Boss" (POE I)

It seems only I am privy to the truth of this world. Innocence doesn't exist, Sin doesn't exist, and the Templar faith is a lie. You can tell them I said so. I'll go down shouting it! And the Karui and Maraketh gods are probably fake, too. It's all a scam, you see. A convenient belief system to keep the rabble in check. The Karui way, Maraketh tradition, the Templars' militant faith, and the Azmeri—well, they're fine actually. Inoffensive. You won't catch me living in the forest, though.

--Niles, "The Truth" (POE I)

I don't know how you convinced a city full of people that you slew some sort of rampaging god, but I've seen artists' depictions of Kitava's supposed rampage. There is no way that the ground could support a being that large. Did you see the footprints? Clearly fake, carved by Templar artisans to deceive the populace. The river of blood was accomplished with diluted crimson mud from the Plains of Vastiri. It's really quite simple when you think about it.

As for your own experience, there are records of gasses seeping from the crypts that once caused a whole village to believe they were fish. They flopped on the ground, gasping for air. They even died! Have you considered you may be a victim of a similar occurrence?

--Niles, "Godslayer" (POE I)

Niles, I can feel you trying to read my thoughts.

--Nenet, "Banter" (POE I)

When I was younger, I served next to some very powerful men. I once caught a stray thought from the High Templar Venarius. A simple picture, nothing more, possible to perceive only because of his overwhelming fear at that moment. I have to assume he was insane, because the image he had in mind was that of a single beleaguered jewel adrift on an ocean of madness. If that was how I saw the world, it would almost be a comfort to believe in gods. At least then there would be somebody who could stand against the tide... but even then... against what I saw...

Just an old man's idle fears. Pay no mind.

--Niles, "The Outer Realms" (POE I)

RATIONAL TOOLS

Ah yes, Exile, I was hoping you would aid me. I have a very simple mission: to prove that gods do not exist. Yes, yes, I know that you believe you have faced them yourself, but I am intent on proving the fraud. You are a victim, like many, of an elaborate facade painted for you by clever con artists. In order to expose them, I shall need a certain piece of equipment, the Thought Extractor. Forced confessions shall save us from mysticism!

Are you ready to see the light?

--Niles, "Rational Tools" (POE I)

I immediately performed my tests with the device we stole, of course, but the random people I accosted with the Thought Extractor truly believed divinity is real. I don't know what else I expected. Instead of finding the truth, all we did was dig up the false narrative they hold dear. In order for this plan to work, we would have to force confessions out of the ones responsible for the

divine facade, but if we knew who they were, then we wouldn't need their confessions! The Thought Extractor is useless! We shall continue our search for the truth some other way.

--Niles, "Rational Tools" (POE I)

A MUNDANE SAMPLE

Interrogation is a flawed art, as we learned together, but now I know of a better method to prove that divinity is false. I have learned the location of a renowned Azmeri artefact known as Viridi's Finger. It supposedly causes enormous plants to grow from almost any soil. Once it is in our possession, we can prove once and for all that Viridi's Finger is a fake and expose the liars for what they are. Prepare yourself, Exile!

--Niles, "A Mundane Sample" (POE I)

It supposedly causes enormous plants to grow from almost any soil. The myth claims we need to sacrifice a baby to make it function, but that's a bit grotesque, even for me.

--Viridi's Finger (POE I)

Hmm. Viridi's Finger did indeed cause enormous plants to grow. You know what that means, don't you?

We've fallen into one of their traps. Clearly, someone has created this to fool us. I don't know whether it is some unknown species of plant, or some sort of hypnotizer, or perhaps some sort of illusion machine, but Viridi's Finger is too dangerous. I shall destroy it, so that no one else will ever be fooled by it again!

--Niles, "A Mundane Sample" (POE I)



VINDERI, THE DISMANTLER

Hm? Ah! Right, Ahem. Vinderi. Pleasure to meet your acquaintance. Err, pleased to make you. Hello.

Name's Vinderi. Did I mention that already? No one alive knows as much about the explosive arts as me. If you want something or someone, or several someones, turned into an unrecognisable, smouldering mess, I'm more than happy to oblige.

--Vinderi, "Introduction" (POE I)

I was walking around the catacombs beneath the square, trying to find my way to the sewers under the courts. Had a huge sack of the blue stuff on my back. Leaving a little trail as I go so I can find my way out. Little azurite fuse trail winding its way back to the storehouse. Cost me an arm and a leg, that powder. Anyway, I'm right under where I thought the High Templar's office was. Start piling the powder up right under his fat arse. Planning to blow him back to Innocence.

Well, I start hearing a hissing noise. And I start seeing the blue light down the end of the tunnel turning an angry red. It's moving towards me quick. And I'm thinking, this is it. This is where it ends for me, but at least I'll blow that high pain in the arse skyward. Then it stops. No hissing. No light. Just a silhouette. Tall as a man ever was. Taller than Tibbs. Don't know how he even got through the storehouse hole. This man... this glorious man!

Put it down! He shouts. It's not worth the trouble. Come. It's time to go! So I put the bag down, and I start walking over to him. Running even. This man saved my life. I swear to myself I'll follow this Eternal Ideal of a man, this statue, this perfect specimen, as far as he will have me. And as I get close, my eyes adjust. This beautiful man comes into focus. His hand is extended to meet me. I reach out mine. There's an electricity between us. And as my fingers lock into his, he slaps a manacle around

my wrist. I'm under arrest for attempted deicide and possession of a dangerous substance. Got me exiled, the pig. Once I got here I just started working for the boss.

What was your question?

--Vinderi, "The Boss" (POE I)

GROCERY LIST

You've got a contract you want me to take a look at? Alright, why not.

Mmhm. Mmm. Yes. Well, everything seems to be in order.

...

...Oh! This was mine! Well, the designs have changed a bit, but the fundamentals are the same. It's a grocery list, except instead of the markets, we're going to an alchemy storehouse I'm not supposed to know exists. And instead of groceries, we're going to collect a number of powders, ichors and minerals I'm running low on. And instead of paying for them, we are going to steal them. So in that sense, it is very unlike a grocery list. Straightforward enough. Ready to go?

--Vinderi, "Grocery List" (POE I)

Just the usual highly-illegal compounds. Don't drop them. It's fine if you do, but don't.

--Alchemical Supplies (POE I)

...Thirty three cubits of cerulean alloy thread, half an ounce of vitriolic talc, two quarts of bishop-blessed cleansing alcohol -- that's for me -- and enough barrel hoops to sink a bloated bonechewer. Perfect.

...Wait. Hold on. Hold on one dang minute. Where the--... Where is the fumarole tar? Don't tell me I forgot the fumarole tar! Without the tar I might as well be baking a tray of Keth flatbread.

Oh dear. I didn't even have it on the list. Sorry, Exile, the error is mine. You've earned your markers. Hopefully I'll have enough left to take out another contract.

--Vinderi, "Grocery List" (POE I)

THE VINDERI BOMB

Hmm? Oh! At last! The Fumarole Tar job! Gods, I've been chomping at the bit for this contract.

I've drawn up plans for a bomb that, well, let's just say it'll put The Ring on the map. Or take it off the map. It might take quite a large area off the map, actually.

I tend to deal with controlled explosions, but who doesn't love an uncontrolled explosion? Whoever's nearby, that's who! But other than them, they're great! And this is going to be really, really great.

There's only one place I know of that houses enough Fumarole Tar for the job, and it has all sorts of other experimental goodies that I'd like to get my hands on, too.

Exile, this thing is really going to set your world on fire. I feel like a child again!

--Vinderi, "The Vinderi Bomb" (POE I)

Hahaha! I'd never've told my kids this, but gods, I love crime. I just love doing a good crime!

--Vinderi, "Banter 5" (POE I)

I've finished it, Exile. It's all done! The Vinderi Bomb is complete at last! I've named it after myself. It's my legacy. Or, the ruins it will leave in its wake will be my legacy. I wonder if it works... Shall we try it out?

We only get one attempt! Let's do it!

--Vinderi, "The Vinderi Bomb" (POE I)

Bwaaahahaha! Had you going there for a bit, didn't I? I may be old, but I've still got a little pop left in my powderkeg. Did you really think I was about to blow us all to Innocence? Give this old man a little credit!

I just wanted to give the good folk here a little show. I call these beauties "Explodey-make-good-lookers". Catchy, eh? Reckon there might be a business in it!

Well, I hope you enjoyed it. Consider it a show of gratitude.

--Vinderi, "Fireworks" (POE I)



ISLA, THE ENGINEER

Got somethin' needs made? Or unmade? I can take 'em apart as fast as I put them together, sometimes faster. Or is it the other way 'round? I've had an idea just now for a spinning device that - oh, yes, my name is Isla. I'm an engineer. Welcome.

--Isla, "Introduction" (POE I)

The Boss? Oof, it's inefficient to ask about the Boss. Believe me. You'll go round and round, a spinning gear 'na machine made of secret parts. The one thing you should never rely on is a mechanism you don't understand. It's liable to implode, or explode. Neither is pretty when your arse is sittin' upon it hopin' to fly somewhere. The Boss put in an order for an air-sail once, for a job. Impossible, I told Kurai. Turned out it worked! It just didn't go with the poor sod we hired. It stayed with us in flames while he took to the skies. He achieved a perfect parabolic arc right onto the tower we were aiming for. Survived the trip, too, judgin' by the screaming. But getting back down? Oof, the Boss never ordered a falling machine. That's on him. Gotta think things through, mind you!

--Isla, "The Boss" (POE I)

Although Isla is often distracted, she is quite kind. She has a strength I have never seen before, one born of machines and intellect rather than fighting skill. I would never admit this to anyone, of course, but her steadfast support makes this place almost feel like a home. That is, when her mechanical spider isn't chewing my belongings.

--Nenet, "Isla" (POE I)

ISLA'S PROTOTYPES

You want to work with *me*? I didn't realize we were that close. This is fantastic! I'll need a partner to retrieve my early prototypes from the hands of the Templars. I made a series of precursor contraptions before I was exiled that would have led to some of my greatest achievements. If you can imagine it, my inventions could have done it... eventually.

I didn't realise who I was working for until it was too late. They seized my prototypes and exiled me for the damage I caused in the process of building them. What's a few implosions in the pursuit of progress? Or maybe it was the sea tide of acid... or the glowing rock that made people sick... oh, yes.

--Isla, "Isla's Prototypes" (POE I)

My inventions! My babies! I missed them so much. I would never have found the proper materials to recreate them here on Wraecclast, not with all the horrific creatures roaming about. Thank you, Exile!

--Isla, "Isla's Prototypes" (POE I)

ISLA'S DESIGNS

As I studied the prototypes you helped me retrieve, I realized that they'd already been examined... by someone else. The Templars must have lied about declaring my work heretical. They're trying to build them for their own gain! I cannot imagine what disaster they'll bring upon us if they manage to do so.

We already have the prototypes, so now we must steal the designs they created based on them. We'll need to steal the blueprints for my Extreme Warmth Beam, my Storm Wooing Rod... hmm, the Mind Sublimator... and the Unbreakable, of course! I don't claim to be the most imaginative namer, but it is what it is. They're all related, eventually intended to be part of one single superweapon, so the designs should all be in one place.

Let's go retrieve those blueprints!

--Isla, "Isla's Designs" (POE I)

We did it, Exile, at least in part. The designs for the Unbreakable were missing... I fear that they may have begun construction on it. If they complete the Unbreakable, we'll never be able to... break it. Science deserves better masters than the Templars!

--Isla, "Isla's Designs" (POE I)

BREAKING THE UNBREAKABLE

My instruments have started going haywire. I believe the Templar have managed to build the Unbreakable, *my* greatest achievement. Normally, I would be thrilled at seeing my work given life, but I have a feeling the Unbreakable will be used against us, not for us.

It's time to do some deconstruction. You're good at smashing things, yes? Then perhaps you can break the Unbreakable.

--Isla, "Breaking the Unbreakable" (POE I)

Stop, in the name of science!

--Isla, at start of fight (POE I)

My baby... my proudest work... Wait! I still have the blueprints! Let's go, Exile!

--Isla, at end of fight (POE I)

The Unbreakable has been broken. You know what that means, don't you?

The Templar didn't build it right. I'll have to continue my work to prove it can be done!

--Isla, "Breaking the Unbreakable" (POE I)



WHAKANO, THE BARBER

Tala moana and good tidings! I'm Whakano, though most people know me as the Barber. If you need a trim and tidy then take a seat. But a little fishy told me you may be more interested in a conversation than a cut.

A man like myself, travelling around as much as I do, hears a lot of things. Everyone needs their hair cut once in a while, and I am a very attentive listener.

Some of the things I hear could be very lucrative to people with certain, shall we say, unscrupulous ambitions.

Drop a few markers in the tip jar, and I may accidentally drop some of my meticulously well-kept notes.

--Whakano, "Introduction" (POE I)

Troubling news coming out of Oriath. I know you weren't just involved, but smack-dab in the middle of things. I also know you aren't to blame. Not directly, anyway.

Still, you might imagine that I feel some... animosity about the whole situation. Not least of all because the presence of Kitava is quite literally a doomsday scenario for my people.

I trust you'll sort it out, 'cause if you don't, we're through. And I don't just mean no more business.

--Whakano, "Kitava" (POE I)

The rebellion was a long time coming, if you ask me, which you did. And if you ask me, which you didn't, I reckon the bloodshed was inevitable. The gods rising up? That one, I will admit, took me by surprise. So now the Karui are sailing back home -- good. But anger has a tendency to linger like a bad smell, and the enslaved are justifiably angry. It may take a long time before that anger fades. It may never.

--Whakano, "Slaves" (POE I)

Faustus: What do your people think about what happened in Oriath?

Whakano: Barbers, sir?

Faustus: Karui! Are they dancing round their totems singing the praises of the return of their saviour?

Whakano: Kitava is no saviour. Far from it. Kitava is symbolic of death, of the end of all things.

Faustus: Eh? I thought that was, uh, hinny--something.

Whakano: Hinekora? The Mother of Death is the steward of our souls, but she has no great desire to destroy us. It's a common misunderstanding among your people.

Faustus: Eternals?

Whakano: Captains. I cannot speak for all Karui, but personally, I feel a great sadness for Oriath. Many people lost their lives, their homes, their families. Good people. Bad people too, but even bad people should have the opportunity to reflect on their misdeeds and change. Kitava took that opportunity away.

Faustus: Quite right. Quite right.

--Faustus & Whakano, "Banter A" (POE I)

Listen, I don't want to be a nay-sayer, but before you started coming around here, we didn't have none of this god nonsense. They were just characters in stories. Ways to get the kiddos to eat their greens. And that was fine! In fact, I preferred it that way!

Now? We've got characters coming to life! And then you're killing 'em! You're killing our heroes! Tukohama was one of the good guys! You better finish what you started.

--Whakano, "Tukohama" (POE I)

Well, at least you followed through eh? I'd have preferred if my gods stayed tucked away neatly in their tales, but if we're going to have the Ravenous One up and about, at least we have you to put him back to bed for good.

--Whakano, "Kitava" (POE I)

Let's say you're a wealthy Oriathan slave merchant. You're out there, selling people to other people, really raking in the coin off the back of racial divides. Then one day, those people you've been selling start killing the people you've been selling 'em to! That's gotta be bad for business, right? Time to cut your losses?

Sadly, no. Slavers have had their pride badly bruised. They're out there -- right now -- looking for Karui men, women, even children, and kidnapping 'em. No one's heard from the taken since. You think they're getting sold to new owners? Not a chance. They're being tortured. Murdered. The slavers see this as revenge, but it is nothing more than evil for evil's sake.

A lot of bad things have come from the rise of Kitava, but this... for me, this is the worst.

--Whakano, "Vigilantes" (POE I)

SLAVER'S REVENGE

Kitava's rebirth has heralded countless tragedies, but there has been one shining light to come from it -- the unshackling of my brothers and sisters. Freed Karui slaves were among the first survivors to reach the shores of Wraecclast. I watched them kiss the sand, sing, dance. I watched them finally enjoy the freedom they should have had all along. Then it started coming unwound.

A man by the name of Hapihapi who was helping the returnees resettle has gone missing. A witness claims he was taken aboard a slaver's ship. I know where that ship took him. I want you to go there. I want you to find him. I want you to free him.

--Whakano, "Slaver's Revenge" (POE I)

Wish I was surprised by this turn of events. I really do. This is just another line on a page, in a book writ only of atrocities against the Karui people. I fear this is not some aberrant event, but is the beginning of a pattern.

I appreciate your effort, though. I will stay vigilant. I hope you do, as well.

I will send a message to Hapihapi's friends and family. They will give him an honourable send-off.

--Whakano, "Slaver's Revenge" (POE I)

FOLLOW THE PAPER TRAIL

Sometimes I hate being right. Hapihapi's kidnapping was followed by a string of similar kidnappings. All Karui, some barely old enough to walk. Even in this time of madness and upheaval, as dead Oriathans are still being put to rest, slavers are taking my brothers and sisters. Different

ships, but the methods they're using are too similar to be coincidence. Someone is in charge of this, and I want to know who.

The Oriath Records Office holds a lot of documents, including sales records of slaves, slaver licenses, and records of the whereabouts and ownership of every known slave. Get me those documents.

--Whakano, "Follow the Paper Trail" (POE I)

Many thanks, Exile. Leave these documents with me. I'll send a few little fishies upstream and see what they come back with.

--Whakano, "Follow the Paper Trail" (POE I)

THE SLAVER KING

Here's the thing about slavers; without the blessing of the Templar authorities, they collapse under pressure like a sandcastle.

My little fishies have come back, and they've brought with them a name: Friedrich Tarollo.

Not surprised you haven't heard of him. He was small-time. But even in a career known for callousness and cruelty, Friedrich was a real bastard. Loved the chase. Loved the struggle. Left his mark on the backs of many of my brothers and sisters.

It seems he has holed himself up in a cave somewhere, declared himself the supreme ruler of the slavers, and is enjoying the lawlessness Oriath's collapse has brought to a sickening degree. Find him and bring him to justice.

--Whakano, "The Slaver King" (POE I)

I heard the news, Exile. Tarollo is dead. The message is loud and clear to those who care to listen; the Karui people are a free people, and will not bend to threats and terror, not now, not ever.

Maybe this was just a job for you, maybe it was more. I don't much care either way. What matters is that you enacted change. For that, you have earned my markers and my respect.

--Whakano, "The Slaver King" (POE I)



GIANNA, THE MASTER OF DISGUISE

Hey good lookin'. Huh. Most people recognise me. I'm Gianna. Worked a spell in the Chitus Theatre, back when you could leave your house without being followed by Templar secret police. I was Shavronne in *An Axiom Tragedy*. I played Diallya, the Gemling Queen, in *Purity Tales*, and the fair lady Merveil in *Daresso and Merveil*, for which I was very nearly nominated to receive a 'Tario.

No? Not a fan of the theatre, I suppose? That's-... That's fine. That act of my story has drawn to a close anyway, but I'm always looking for the next great role. Nothing's quite so thrilling as immersing oneself among the people, and seeing if you can, in fact, pass for the real deal.

--Gianna, "Introduction" (POE I)

I wasn't exactly planning on a life of crime. Yes, most in my profession do end up begging or stealing, but my career was on the up and up, until I was accused of *Pecuniary Lust* and exiled.

It just so happens that the Boss, cultural elite that he is, saw me in a few shows. He must have noticed my ability to fully embody any role, to become not just the character, but the person. I'm told he was a practitioner of the performing arts himself, in his youth. Obviously, he has a keen eye for talent.

I'm dying to perform a dialogue with him. Good material is hard to come by 'round here, but I did find a piece by a Bestel floating in the foam. Not particularly engaging, and a frankly unhealthy focus on the female lead's figure in the stage direction, but it's something, at least.

Alas, Kurai maintains the Boss' schedule, and I'm told he is booked up indefinitely. Imagine having lucrative work for months to come! A performer can only dream...

--Gianna, "The Boss" (POE I)

THE NAMELESS PLAY

Just my luck! Of course you are put on my contract. Do you even know anything about the theatre? The cursed play? The one no performer should ever name, lest they end up consumed by the phantom that haunts it?

It's said that the play's author wrote it while high as an eagle on ergot. He didn't know, of course, and died upon penning the final word.

The play, whose name I shall not utter, is about a beautiful young lady who finds herself swept into a world beneath the sands of the Vastiri, where the dead have built a city of bones. She marries a statue, becomes the queen of this city, and then her skin peels off and a hundred little versions of her spill out. Completely nutty.

It's locked up with the rest of the works deemed distasteful by the Templar, and I simply must have it.

--Gianna, "The Nameless Play" (POE I)

I heard the script will send any who attempt to perform it mad, but other than that, it is very good.

--"The Nameless Play" (POE I)

Marilla turns to her beloved's unmoving face and speaks the blessed words:

Marilla: Two into one, one into many, to churn the world beneath the crashing dunes.

Marilla's body shatters like porcelain, each fragment becoming Marilla. Each new Marilla shatters again, and again, each fragment becomes whole. The stage is flooded by Marilla. All is Marilla. The statue rises and exits stage right.

Fin.

Wow. I mean... wow. That was something! Right? That... that was something, right?

I think I might just stick to the unbanned works for a little while, actually. Thanks, though.

--Gianna, "The Nameless Play" (POE I)

THE FINEST COSTUMES

You're handling my contract again? I thought I specifically requested someone with a working understanding of the arts! Fine, fine. It's just a job. Well, I'm sure you've done the necessary reading, but I'm dying to gab a bit.

When I worked with the Theopolis Thespian Society, there was an old, old, *old* woman. I mean, at *least* forty. She was our seamstress. She created these costumes that looked just like the real thing. Blackguard uniforms, Templar outfits, you name it. Well, one day she vanished, but the costumes remained.

I want to get ahold of that old woman's costumes. They were just so... believable! With those, it'll be much easier to slip into a role undetected.

--Gianna, "The Finest Costumes" (POE I)

Make sure it'll fit a small man, or a very large child. And check for stains! Knew a few people who'd use them for-...

...Just check for stains.

--Templar Uniforms (POE I)

I don't know how she did it. Each outfit so perfectly matches the original piece. It's almost as if- ...what!? *Property of Templar Logistics Office*!? They're the genuine article! That woman stole real bloody uniforms! Well, I guess that explains why they always looked so genuine. It also explains why we didn't ever see her again.

Oh well, her loss is our gain!

--Gianna, "The Finest Costumes" (POE I)



NENET, THE SCOUT

Nenet is from a people that currently call themselves the Faridun. They are our rejects. Those we Maraketh left to die in the desert as children for being unworthy or flawed. I do not think ill of Nenet. I do not think of her at all.

I am not cruel, exile. It is simply that scattered groups of pariahs wandering in the desert have no effect on the world. She will not find the home she yearns for among these scoundrels.

--Adiyah, "Nenet" (POE I)

You are an exile? Then you, too, have had your rightful home stolen from you - unless you actually committed the crimes you were accused of.

But of course you haven't. We are all innocent here, yes?

--Nenet, "Introduction" (POE I)

I have been looking for someone to follow my entire life. Someone to inspire me, to give meaning and community to my days. The Boss is... to put it bluntly, not that man. However, he is better than nothing.

Because of what he has built here, we unwanted scum have what some could call a society. Here, everyone is welcome regardless of station or ability, provided they are willing to work. The Boss has made it so.

--Nenet, "The Boss" (POE I)

It is an elegant lie, that name: the 'Plains' of Vastiri. I know it only as a harsh desert, a blasted wasteland of broken rock, crimson sands, and salted earth. Those who call it the 'Plains' see it as it was thousands of years ago. They are deluded.

But who am I to judge? I still believe I'll find a home someday, even with a face like mine. Perhaps we all need a few delusions to keep us sane. What's your flavour of madness, Exile?

--Nenet, "The Plains of Vastiri" (POE I)

THE BOOK OF JAMANRA

[Note: The following contract was fully scripted in 3.12, but to date has not been released.]

I am honoured, Exile, that one of your strength would even speak to me, let alone help me. I am an outcast, and it is that very status which drives me for this mission. I have traveled far, and for many years, to find the resources and allies to do what I intend. Here I am in this place, before you now, ready.

Where I am from, the Plains of Vastiri, the Maraketh hold no pity for the weak or the supposedly useless. The other outcasts found me and raised me, and though our lives are harsh, we have a meager culture of our own. We call ourselves the Faridun. The Maraketh believe we are worthless and flawed, but I am convinced I can prove that is not true.

There is a legend among my people of a bold warrior who tried to unite the scattered Faridun camps thousands of years ago. His name was Jamanra, and he wished only to unify us so that we might come into our own as a people. If I can prove that he existed by finding the Book of Jamanra, then I may be able to initiate a ritual challenge with the Maraketh to test Faridun warriors for worthiness. If we pass, they will have to accept us back into the lives we should have had! Will you help me win back my home, Exile?

--Nenet, "The Book of Jamanra" (POE I)

If we can prove Jamanra existed, then the Faridun may have a chance to rejoin the Maraketh. I, for one, would like to meet my parents. I have many questions...

--The Book of Jamanra (POE I)

Jamanra did exist, Exile... and they killed him. The Sekhemas agreed to meet with him to discuss recognizing the Faridun nation, but it was a trick. They poisoned him. The supposedly honourable high-and-mighty Maraketh poisoned our greatest leader.

I suppose I should have expected nothing less from this brutal world we live in, Exile. You and I know best that hope is an illusion, and that raw force is the only way to take anything for oneself. In any case, I thank you for aiding me.

--Nenet, "The Book of Jamanra" (POE I)

JAMANRA'S REST

[Note: The following contract was fully scripted in 3.12, but to date has not been released.]

I have come to a decision, Exile. I do not believe the Maraketh will ever willingly give us a home, or let us make our own. The Book you helped me retrieve tells Jamanra's tale, but it goes a bit further than that. It also tells of his final resting place. You can already guess what I intend, yes? In this land of madness where the dead rise and legendary figures return, I have a reasonable suspicion Jamanra can be found and released from his tomb.

If the Maraketh will not listen to our peaceful pleas, then perhaps we Faridun will carve a home for ourselves on the Plains of Vastiri with the sharp edge of a sword. Jamanra can finish what he began thousands of years ago, and if he is empowered by Corruption this time around, then no cowardly poison will be able to stop him.

Help me find Jamanra in his tomb and convince him to lead our cause, Exile!

--Nenet, "Jamanra's Rest" (POE I)

If Jamanra has been resurrected the way so many other ancient heroes have returned, then perhaps I can convince him to rise up and unite the Faridun once more!

--Contract: Jamanra's Rest (POE I)

The Scourge of the Vastiri will ride once more. All will bow - or die!

We who have nothing need nothing.

We who need nothing have everything!

All shall serve!

Cower before Jamanra!

We will... rise... again...

--Jamanra, during fight (POE I)

Jamanra was a raving mad monster... there is no hope, Exile. I appreciate your aid, but I no longer see a way forward. Who was I to think that I could change thousands of years of brutal tradition? This life of thievery and villainy is all that there is for me.

I think I'm going to take refuge in mead from now on.

--Nenet, "Jamanra's Rest" (POE I)



ADIYAH, THE WAYFINDER

I am Adiyah. I will enable your travel to and from locations of interest.

--Adiyah, "Introduction" (male version) (POE I)

This place runs foul with thieves, cutthroats, and loudmouths. I am likely the only one here that would not betray you for coin.

--Adiyah, "Rogue Harbour" (male version) (POE I)

I once served a worthy Sekhema. The Boss is no Sekhema. He rules through deception, obfuscation, and manipulation. However, if he agrees to do something, he will do it. That in itself is a form of honour which I can respect.

He expects the same of us. In exchange for a place here, I have agreed to use my skills to enable the travels of this wretched heap of rhoa dung, and that is what I will do. My word is my bond.

--Adiyah, "The Boss" (POE I)

A MATTER OF HONOUR

This contract touches upon my very reason for being here. It concerns my sister, Nashta, and a Spear. Growing up, Nashta was unable to follow the traditions of our people. She chafed at the rules. She earned many tattoos of shame for her violations, and each time she was punished, she only grew more rebellious.

Not long ago, she fled from the Plains of Vastiri entirely, and scores of delinquents went with her. They have since terrorised many with their banditry, but duty required I track her down when she stole Solerai's Spear from a Sarn merchant of ill repute. I live among these thieves and scoundrels because this is her world, and in this place I hear more about her activities in a single moon than I would in a year spent looking for her on my own.

We must retrieve the Spear. We cannot allow her to wield a weapon of Maraketh tradition in so disrespectful a manner. This is my duty, as Nashta is my sister. This contract makes it your duty as well.

--Adiyah, "A Matter of Honour" (POE I)

This Spear is a tremendous weapon, one fit for a goddess. The merchant Hargan expects its return, but he shall be disappointed. When I bring it home to my *akhara*, our honour will be partially restored in the eyes of our fellow warriors. You did well, Exile.

--Adiyah, "A Matter of Honour" (POE I)

FLYING FALSE COLOURS

My sister, Nashta, and her bandits have responded to our retrieval of Solerai's Spear by targeting their raids against other Maraketh caravans. That in itself is not shameful, but she is doing so while wearing the colors of my *akhara*. She is trying to start a war among our people, and we can hardly afford conflict when our survival already hangs by a thread.

You and I must infiltrate her stronghold and retrieve her war plans. With that proof, we can ensure that the Sekhemas know who is truly to blame.

--Adiyah, "Flying False Colours" (POE I)

This war journal contains exactly what I hoped. This, combined with my word, should be enough for the Sekhemas to believe that Nashta is acting on her own. I thank you, Exile.

--Adiyah, "Flying False Colours" (POE I)

HEART OF GLORY

I know my sister. Nashta responds to adversity by invigorating her resistance, not backing down. We retrieved Solerai's Spear and thwarted her attempt to spark a civil war among the Maraketh, but that will only cause her to up the scale of her banditry. We must face her before she causes a disaster that our people can ill afford in these dangerous times.

This will not be a matter of stealth, exile. Be prepared to fight if she will not listen to words.

--Adiyah, "Bad Blood" (POE I)

A part of me still believes I can convince Nashta to give up her rebellious ways and come home. That part of me will forever be nine years of age, futilely chasing her as she runs off into the dunes yet again.

--Contract: Heart of Glory (POE I)

Adiyah: Nashta! It is time to come home.

Nashta: You know I cannot, sister. My soul yearns for freedom!

Adiyah: You could *try*.

Nashta: I cannot live under those tyrants.

Adiyah: I understand. I will give you the only freedom I can.

Nashta: I would rather die than go back!

Nashta: Thank you, Adiyah. Sister.

Adiyah: You fought well, Nashta. I am proud of you.

--Adiyah & Nashta, during fight (POE I)

This was the best end I could have wished for Nashta. I think it was what she always wanted: not to live under the heavy oppression of a rigid set of rules, but to die fighting, as a true *dekhara*. In death, by standing and fighting, she has cleared her shame. She will be remembered as a woman filled with the irrepressible spirit of the warrior, one with so much aggression that she had no place in this civilised world.

I will retrieve her body. Leave me now. I have some final things to say to my sister that are not for a jingakh to hear. Go well, my friend.

--Adiyah, "Bad Blood" (POE I)

I prefer not to name my *akhara* in the presence of these persons of ill repute, but I can say that I am from the northern reaches of the Plains of Vastiri. My home caravan has ninety-two carts, all of which are beautifully set with colourful tapestries and shaped metal. It is a life and land unlike this one. Difficult, duty-bound, but rewarding. I will return there someday, when my duty here is at an end.

I still owe a debt to the Boss for allowing me a place here. Nashta may be dead, but I will stay here for a few more moons.

--Adiyah, "Home" (POE I)



FAUSTUS, THE FENCE

Another green footpad? The turnover here...

Listen carefully, for I do not like to repeat myself.

My name is Faustus. I am your fence. If you have something of value, you come to me. Understood? Every other day we have some braindead upstart who thinks they can circumvent the system. They go gallivanting around proclaiming they've found a gilded wonder or somesuch. Either the Templar, or another, less charitable, organisation gets wind of it, and we never see them again. Well, sometimes we see parts of them... usually on a pike or smeared across the ground at the base of the towers.

I am here for a reason. I am your protector. I am what stands between you and a very short life as a fugitive. I am your plausible deniability. Follow the rules, and you will grow wealthy and stay healthy.

--Faustus, "Introduction" (POE I)

A fence like myself provides a thief like yourself the means to offload ill-gotten goods for something you'll find more useful; in this case, markers. I take those goods and sell them to the nobility for something I find more useful -- coin and prestige. As a captain in the Navy, it's not entirely unusual to confiscate illicit goods from pirates and smugglers, and the nobility happily reward me for retrieving their valuables from the hands of evil.

Sometimes I'll even return it pro-bono, if the owner's station may afford me certain privileges down the road. The job carries with it certain risks, but were a thief such as yourself to try to speak out

against me, well, you'd only be incriminating yourself in the process. It'd be your word against mine. And who is a judge more likely to believe?

--Faustus, "Fence" (POE I)

Whakano: How are things aboard your ship, sir?

Faustus: The Marylene? Oh, you know... Get a bunch of men in a small space and there's bound to be bickering and brawling. The ol' lashing arm's been getting a good workout, I must say.

Whakano: Do they mind you spending all this time here, sir?

Faustus: Well they don't exactly know I'm here, per se, but I imagine, rascallions that they are, they savour any time where the man-in-charge is absent. In my day, we'd tie up the first mate, break into the swill, and see who could down the most before passing out or dying.

Whakano: You must've met the lash when your captain came back, eh?

Faustus: Oh, no. No no no. Most of us came from good, Innocence-fearing families. The captain knew that raising a hand to us would put him in hot water back home. We got away with murder, really. No, really, a few of the boys beat a galley slave to death. Barely got a talking to. Nowadays, of course, Admiral Darnaw lets damn-near anyone join the ranks. Horrible policy. I do enjoy doling out the punishments, though.

--Whakano & Faustus, "Banter A" (POE I)

Awful business, what happened to Oriath. Terrible. Just terrible. I was lucky. Safely out at sea with my crew.

I hope those responsible are held accountable, barring those with whom I have ongoing business, of course. I suspect they were merely in the wrong place at the wrong time. Can't blame someone for having rotten luck!

--Faustus, "Oriath" (POE I)

Faustus: Strange turn of events, eh Karui?

Whakano: Are you speaking to me, sir?

Faustus: Never imagined my people living peacefully with your people, let alone on your lands!

Whakano: No? Some would say you've been living on Karui islands for generations.

Faustus: Well, they were our islands by then, weren't they? Anyway, perhaps I should thank you.

Whakano: Me?

Faustus: Though our beautiful metropolis is now but smoldering ruins, you have given us a new home. A chance to build society anew. Hope.

Whakano: I didn't do any of that, sir.

Faustus: You know what I mean! Learn to accept a compliment.

Whakano: I'm sorry, sir. Allow me to return a compliment: Thank you for not trampling our homes, taking our children, our brothers and sisters, our wives and husbands, and binding their arms and legs when you washed ashore. Thank you for limiting your recolonisation to one island, and for breaking only a few of our laws and traditions in these early days.

Faustus: You're very welcome. See? It's not hard.

--Faustus & Whakano, "Banter B" (POE I)

THE ADMIRAL'S RECORDS

My contract! How delightful. A shrewd man knows when to be discreet, but I like you, Exile. I like your bravado. Your gumption. Your get-it-done attitude. You deserve a little background.

I was aboard my vessel, the *Fair Marylene*, when I saw the first plumes rising above my beloved Theopolis. And thank Innocence! What those savages did... It is indefensible. But, it strikes me that within such a tragedy lies an opportunity.

The Theocracy is all but dead, thanks to you, but the military structure, in large part, remains intact. That's a problem. Admiral Darnaw, Innocence save him, is a buffoon. He is such a buffoon, that I would be willing to bet he has documented his buffoonery. Prove me right, and I'll reward you handsomely. And richly! Ha! Do you get it? I was hinting at my natural good looks for humorous effect. Wordplay is so satisfying.

--Faustus, "The Admiral's Records" (POE I)

Let's see what you've fished up. Hmm. Love letters? Well, nearly everyone's had their hand in Piety's cookiejar, so-to-speak, so that won't do. But these... Yes, these might work. Exile, have you already perused these papers?

Perhaps of little consequence to a layperson like yourself, these papers are irrefutable proof that Darnaw has been personally funding the activities of the Brinerot Pirates!

What? Don't look at me like that. This is an entirely different situation. The Brinerot are awful, bootlegging buccaneers! You are a ragtag bunch of down-on-your-luck ne'er-do-wells just trying to make the best life you can in this crazy world. Plus, I do no business with the Brinerot. Completely different.

--Faustus, "The Admiral's Records" (POE I)

I've been in the navy a long time. I've seen leaders come and go. Let me tell you; Darnaw is a fool. A bumpkin. A cretin! I've no doubt he is morally corrupt, but more offensive than that, he holds no regard for a man's heritage! Back in my day, the navy was where boys became men. Where well-bred Oriathans could earn their place among the elite, after a brief and relatively safe stint out at sea. Then Darnaw came along, and all of a sudden we have fellows from completely inconsequential families strutting around the cabins like they work there! Because they do! He lets them work there! Awful man, Darnaw. Just awful.

--Faustus, "Admiral Darnaw" (POE I)

FINDINGS FOR FIDIUM

Exile! How ever have you been since however long we uh--... Listen. That little job you pulled for me went nowhere. I showed Darnaw the papers, and he had the gall, the GALL, to shrug! At me! He said 'What are you going to do, arrest me?'. I said 'I might!' And now I'm blackballed! No orders coming through from him, and no communications coming from any of the other surviving vessels.

So, bit of a setback. Not the end of the world... Well, pending all this divine stuff going on. Plan B is underway.

I've a bit of a rivalry with another captain. Fidium. Clean as a whistle, Captain Fidium. Barnacles wouldn't stick to his hull. He's long had it out for me. Suspects me of underhanded dealings, the clever sod. I want you to break into his home and plant Darnaw's incriminating papers there. Put them where he's likely to find them. Probably a desk, or the latrine. Ehhhh... Desk. Let's go with the desk idea. He'll find the papers, confront Darnaw, and, WHAM! Sink two ships with one larger, stronger, handsomer ship.

--Faustus, "Findings for Fidium" (POE I)

How did you do, Exile? Did you leave them by the latrine? Oh--wait, we settled on the desk, didn't we. Ah. Shame.

Hmm? What did you find there? Aaah... Ah HA! Fidium, you fool! These, my dear, useful friend, are Fleet Orders, direct from Darnaw himself. We now know the entire fleet's future movements, including Darnaw's.

Yes... Yes... A plan is forming. Leave it with me, Exile. There's work to be done.

--Faustus, "Findings for Fidium" (POE I)

If Admiral Darnaw is stupid enough to send orders to his fleet members and not expect us to steal them, then he deserves what's coming to him!

--Contract: Death to Darnaw (POE I)

DEATH TO DARNAW

Just the person I was looking for! And you even have my contract in hand. How fortuitous! I've spent a good long while thinking over our next move. There are many pieces in play, and we must act decisively if we are to enact the change I seek. We seek. The change WE seek.

Here it is. We kill Darnaw.

That's it. Brilliant, eh? We go to Darnaw's location, and we kill him. YOU kill him. You go to Darnaw's location and kill him. I'm going to stay here. Hands clean and all that. Couldn't be simpler!

Well, go on then!

--Faustus, "Death to Darnaw" (POE I)

Admiral Darnaw's dead? Then you should be addressing me more formally! For I, Faustus, am the new Admiral! Well, I will be very soon. I'll send a small crew to investigate Captain Fidium's residence. I suspect they may find some damning evidence of Darnaw's corruption that must have pushed fastidious Fidium into a fit of fury! A quick keelhauling, and presto! No loose ends. We'll have to use my ship for the keelhauling of course. Fidium's keel is notoriously clean.

Thanks to your hard work, I can now consolidate the Oriath navy under my banner. The largest military force, mine to control, sitting at the centre of all trade!

I do believe this deserves a toast. To me! Long live the Admiral!

--Faustus, "Death to Darnaw" (POE I)



KURAI, THE ADMINISTRATOR

I do not like to talk about my younger days, except to say that I did what I had to in order to survive, and I am glad that time is behind me.

--Kurai, "Oriath" (POE I)

While I feel for those lost in the wake of Oriath's fall, forgive me if I do not shed a tear for the city which, even now, fills my nights with terror.

--Kurai, "Oriath" (POE I)

HYRRI'S GIFT

You've got a contract I have taken out. Excuse me if you know the tale, but I find a well-informed thief is a better thief.

A few hundred years ago, Kaom, a Karui king of note, landed on the shores of Wraecclast and began an ill-fated conquest north. He won a decisive battle against the Eternals with the help of his niece, Hyrri. She and many other women took up bows and ambushed General Lioneve when hubris got the better of him. It was an ingenious workaround of a restriction of the Karui Way.

The poet Victario was present at the battle and later gifted Hyrri with a signed copy of "O' Eternal", one of his works. It now sits in the vault of an Oriathan nobleman. I'd like you to bring it home. It should be a straightforward job.

--Kurai, "Hyrri's Gift" (POE I)

A symbolic piece of history, from a time when people of all backgrounds united against a common enemy.

--"O' Eternal" (POE I)

You got the book. Some moisture damage, but otherwise it seems to be in good condition.

*To my Karui Queen,
The Ngamakanui rose has never been so beautiful
nor its thorns so deadly.
Let your aim never waiver,
And your story ever be told.*

Thank you. I'll make sure it finds its way back to Ngamakanui, where it belongs.

--Kurai, "Hyrri's Gift" (POE I)

THE NEGOTIATION

This job is a bit... unorthodox. Do you recall the book I had you rehome? Well, its owner was quite fond of it. He took out a contract and, it seems, wants to negotiate for the book's return.

I don't wish to involve The Boss in this, since the original contract was mine. I'm going to travel with you to meet the client to make sure there's no funny-business.

--Kurai, "The Negotiation" (POE I)

Vic Vox: Well would you look at that. Didn't think you'd come in person! How are you, lady Kurai? Did you enjoy the book?

Kurai, the Administrator: We can skip the pleasantries, Vox.

Vic Vox: If you wish for this to be unpleasant, so be it. I want my book back.

Kurai, the Administrator: *The* book is no longer in my possession.

Vic Vox: Where is it?

Kurai, the Administrator: Where it belongs. Are we done?

Vic Vox: Kurai, Kurai, Kurai... Don't you feel you're being unfair? You did, after all, break into my home. You took something which I value. O' Eternal. A first edition. Signed by Victario himself. My

parents, rest their souls, were so fond of his work that I was named after him! Am I not owed some sort of... reparations?

Kurai, the Administrator: Tell me what you want.

Vic Vox: I want *my* book. And since you don't have it... Kurai, I presume this is the thief? I know you don't do your own dirty work.

Kurai, the Administrator: Vic...

Vic Vox: Tell you what... You can keep the book. Give me the thief's head, and we'll call it even.

Kurai, the Administrator: Ha! You cannot be serious.

Vic Vox: I am deadly serious. Kill them. Now. In front of me.

Kurai, the Administrator: And if I don't?

Vic Vox: Then I will consider the theft an act of aggression against the Vox family. An act of war.

Kurai, the Administrator: You leave me no choice. I'm sorry, Exile. Victario Vox... it appears we are now at war.

Vic Vox: A stupid decision by a weak little girl.

Kurai, the Administrator: Goodbye Mr. Vox. And regards to your brother.

Vic Vox: Every war has casualties, Kurai! Any bloodshed is on you!

--Kurai & Vic, during contract (POE I)

I should have known better. The meeting was pointless from the start. It was a distraction, Exile. They took Hana, my cat, and left a note saying they would be in touch. It was all just a setup.

This is only the beginning, I fear. I'm deeply sorry that I got you involved.

Be careful.

--Kurai, "The Negotiation" (POE I)

The Vox family has enjoyed a place among Oriath's nobility for several generations, but in recent years, Victario and Vincent Vox have used coercion, blackmail, and violence to ensure the family sits at the centre of Oriath's business and social ecosystem. The twins enjoy a legitimate public persona, all while they bury their hands deep in the criminal underworld.

The Boss would, of course, love to see the Vox criminal enterprise dismantled. The Ring competes with the Vox crime family for many of the same jobs. But removing competition is secondary to freeing hard-working families from their looming threat. The Boss is shrewd, not heartless.

--Kurai, "The Vox Twins" (POE I)

THE RESCUE

The Vox twins are offering to return Hana and negotiate a truce, so long as we are willing to meet them in person once more. I doubt this meeting will be any more useful than the last. In fact, we may be walking into an ambush, but I want Hana back. I've put all members on high alert while we are gone, and Adiyah is ready to help us escape if it comes to that.

We'll go when you're ready.

--Kurai, "The Rescue" (POE I)

Kurai, the Administrator: Hello?

Vinny Vox: Look, brother! At last, the guest of honour has arrived, with company.

Vic Vox: The weak little girl brought her big strong bodyguard!

Vinny Vox: You were *meant* to come alone! What's wrong Lady Kurai? Are you afraid of us?

Kurai, the Administrator: Ignore them. Keep moving.

Vinny Vox: You kept us waiting so very long that we got bored. We decided to pass the time. We were playing with little... Hana, was it?

Vic Vox: Lovely name. Beautiful cat. And so affectionate!

Vinny Vox: Very affectionate! And we were having such a pleasant time with her! But then things took a turn!

Vic Vox: Hana swiped at us. Attacked us. We don't like being attacked, do we Vinny?

Vinny Vox: Not at all. Beautiful little Hana was being vicious. Mean.

Vic Vox: Very mean.

Vinny Vox: So we did to Hana what we do to anyone who attacks a Vox.

Kurai, the Administrator: Do you see them anywhere? I--... Oh... oh no. No, no, no...

Vic Vox: Hana attacked her betters. She crossed a line. Do you see, Lady Kurai? Do you *understand*?... Hellooooo? Are you deaf?

Kurai, the Administrator: ... I understand.

Vinny Vox: Good. Then we have a proposal for you. Very favourable. A truce, as long as you never interfere in Vox business again. ... Lady Kurai?

Kurai, the Administrator: ... I have a counter-proposal. How about we kill you, Vincent. And you, Victario. How about we kill both of you, and every member of your wretched family. How about *that*? How does *that* deal sound!?

Vic Vox: ...It seems discussions have broken down.

Vinny Vox: Shame. Farewell, Lady Kurai.

--Kurai, Vic & Vinny, during contract (POE I)

Vic and Vinny are monsters, Exile. Monsters. They terrorise anyone who does not submit and swear fealty. *They killed Hana.*

When it comes to business, The Boss does not normally take personal feelings into consideration, but he has made an exception here. He wants the Vox family dead. Plans are in motion. Stay alert.

--Kurai, "The Rescue" (POE I)

THE TWINS

We have been monitoring communications in the Vox crime family for some time. Vic and Vinny have been careful to remain separate, so as not to invite an ambush, but we believe they are uniting very soon for a celebration.

This is the best time to strike. Please ready yourself.

--Kurai, "The Twins" (POE I)

Kurai, the Administrator: Vincent and Victario Vox!

Vinny Vox: Lady Kurai? How nice of you to join us.

Vic Vox: Unfortunately, the party has drawn to a close.

Vinny Vox: But the fun is just beginning!

Kurai, the Administrator: You petulant, overgrown children! Today you face justice.

Vinny Vox: Vic! No!

Vinny Vox: All this... f...for a book? For a cat?

Kurai, the Administrator: No... for the *family*.

Vinny Vox: Enough, enough! You win...what do you want?

Kurai, the Administrator: Revenge.

--Kurai, Vic & Vinny, during fight (POE I)

Death cannot bring back the dead, but it can bring peace to the living. The Vox family was a source of anguish for more people than I care to mention. With the twins gone, their hold on civilian life is relinquished, at least for now. The increased business we will now receive is a simply a happy coincidence.

And I know, somewhere in Hinekora's hallowed halls, Hana is sinking her claws deep into Vox flesh.

The Boss has authorised me to give you a bonus. Thank you again, Exile.

--Kurai, "The Twins" (POE I)

REPLICA UNIQUE ITEMS

"When they realize our true intent, they will decry us, assault us, and try to crush what we have built. We must stand tall, Qotra, and make the future our own."

--The Forward Gaze (POE I)

Prototype #8 makes it difficult to think negatively, but two fatalities resulted when a lead researcher used an epithet in its presence.

--Replica Doedre's Damning Paua Ring (POE I)

In testing, Prototype #9 had no effect on fired arrows. However, an unknown spell did destroy the entire firing chamber.

--Replica Karui Ward Jade Amulet (POE I)

Useless for our purposes, but perhaps we can sell Prototype #5 to an archmage to fund other experiments.

--Replica Kaom's Heart Glorious Plate (POE I)

Twelve dead, and the seventh lab cannot be entered for several years. Prototype #12 is a 'success,' if we can ever reach it.

--Replica Lioneys's Paws Bronzescall Boots (POE I)

Prototype #7 achieved even greater injury responsiveness than expected, though at considerable cost to the long-term survival rate of the user.

--Replica Ambu's Charge Crusader Chainmail (POE I)

Recommend further production of Prototype #122. It makes an ideal weapon for our suppression troops and guards.

--Replica Ungil's Gauche Boot Knife (POE I)

Test subject walked right through the poison gas defenses, and attempts to slow her failed. Suppression troop six, the 'Furious Flagellants,' have been sent to intervene.

--Replica Alpha's Howl Sinner Tricorne (POE I)

Our superiors were getting anxious for results, and lowered security standards. A single attempt of a spell with this unexpected power destroyed an entire floor.

--Replica Kalisa's Grace Samite Gloves (POE I)

While Prototype #3 does imbue its wearer with strength to match the original, the first researcher to don it burst into flames when he walked into sunlight...

--Replica Abyssus Ezomyte Burgonet (POE I)

Suppression troop two, the 'Martyrs for Science,' were able to seal the portals before Outpost Four was overrun. Only three men survived.

--Replica Poorjoy's Asylum Temple Map (POE I)

A rare unequivocal success, Prototype #11 causes wounds to heal so quickly the type Delta test subject actually survived the entire testing regimen.

--Replica Atziri's Foible Paua Amulet (POE I)

Nothing feels so smooth in the hand as Prototype #66. Results like these may justify everything we do here.

--Replica Soul Taker Siege Axe (POE I)

Prototype #599 offers an incredible defensive power, but at a cost. What underlying physics are at play here, I wonder?

--Replica Kongor's Undying Rage Terror Maul (POE I)

The remarkable imbalance of Prototype #848 leads to uncommon power or speed when striking.

--Replica Wings of Entropy Ezomyte Axe (POE I)

Prototype #412 seems to bear much in common with Thought Extractor technology.

--Replica Leer Cast Festival Mask (POE I)

An intriguing paradox.

--Replica Lavianga's Spirit Sanctified Mana Flask (POE I)

A type Delta test subject escaped with Prototype #18. He was last seen ten times the height of a man and crashing straight through walls.

--Replica Headhunter Leather Belt (POE I)

Attempt #306: The power I can sense in this ancient branch still eludes me. Perhaps if I attach some string and a hook...

--Replica Fencoil Gnarled Branch (POE I)

Prototype #722 might look like a helmet, but I believe it to be something else entirely. The visions it shows the wearer... are beyond mortal endurance...

--Replica Veil of the Night Great Helmet (POE I)

Starving test subject became completely incapable of exerting force. However, after being fed, he began to poison everything he touched...

--Replica Alberon's Warpath Soldier Boots (POE I)

So close, yet frustratingly distinct. Something more is going on here...

--Replica Voideye Unset Ring (POE I)

One of our researchers cut himself on Prototype #2, and he has not stopped screaming for months...

--Replica Atziri's Acuity Vaal Gauntlets (POE I)

Physical forces and flames seem to share some innate bond. What logic lies beneath the veil of reality?

--Replica Blood Thorn Gnarled Branch (POE I)

A legion of forty soldiers attempted to break into Outpost Five and steal Prototype #659. What do they know that we do not?

--Replica Prismweave Rustic Sash (POE I)

Likely our closest to the original, yet Prototype #22 still falls short. Are these objects actually somehow resisting our efforts?

--Replica Tasalio's Sign Sapphire Ring (POE I)

Further research must be done on Prototype #282. There is power here, if it can be tapped.

--Replica Restless Ward Carnal Armour (POE I)

Energy redirected is energy imbalanced. Prototype #78 serves as a prime example.

--Replica Twyzel Sage Wand (POE I)

Distribute Prototype #723 to the guards. Perhaps their survival rate will increase.

--Replica Fragile Bloom Crimson Jewel (POE I)

The effect is subtle, but potentially lethal...

--Replica Conqueror's Efficiency Crimson Jewel (POE I)

Prototype #131 must never be allowed near anyone who bears a wound, no matter how slight. Even a tiny cut makes it exponentially more dangerous.

--Replica Bloodplay Stiletto (POE I)

Prototype #298 must be contained in a non-conductive glass box at all times.

--Replica Reckless Defence Cobalt Jewel (POE I)

Admittedly lacking the finesse of the fabled original, Prototype #4 achieved identical results through brute force alone.

--Replica Iron Commander Death Bow (POE I)

Attempt #2520: Been slaving away at this one for longer than I can remember. Convinced this assignment is retribution from my superior...

--Replica Bitterdream Shadow Sceptre (POE I)

Additional test subjects approved. Determine exactly how many wounds need to be endured to activate Prototype #612's energies.

--Replica Advancing Fortress Gut Ripper (POE I)

The best place for this prototype would be in the hands of our enemies.

--Replica Trypanon Great Mallet (POE I)

Three test subjects confirmed Prototype #495 creates an additional debilitating effect from poisons. This could be very useful.

--Replica Frostbreath Ornate Mace (POE I)

Test subjects were unable to strike even a motionless target. However, when a trained guard tried it...

--Replica Tempestuous Steel War Sword (POE I)

Success! Prototype #54 has tapped into that sliver of divinity that exists within. Faith fuels the flesh, and the flesh fuels the fire...

--Replica Sorrow of the Divine Sulphur Flask (POE I)

A curious jewel. Like so many others, a shining little paradox.

--Replica Cheap Construction Viridian Jewel (POE I)

The test subject nearly escaped, but the poison gas system in the hallway functioned as expected.

--Replica Three-step Assault Shagreen Boots (POE I)

Test subject was able to walk into the walls of his chamber after breaking a rabbit's neck. He was not fast enough, however. Suggest we begin excavation to retrieve prototype.

--Replica Voidwalker Murder Boots (POE I)

The summoned golems immediately battered through the chamber wall and killed several guards, but their fury only lasted a short time.

--Replica Primordial Might Crimson Jewel (POE I)

As one of our few creations that did not cost any fatalities, Prototype #10 bore unexpectedly positive results.

--Replica Tukohama's Fortress Ebony Tower Shield (POE I)

Lab Two suffered significant structural damage in the process of creating Prototype #77. It is, however, the closest we've come to perfection.

--Replica Duskdawn Maelström Staff (POE I)

There seems to be some innate relationship between the forces of chaos and cold. Perhaps we should consult an occultist.

--Replica Allelopathy Sorcerer Gloves (POE I)

Prototype #73 is a near perfect opposite of the original. Perhaps our failures are due to some unknown polarity we have yet to discover.

--Replica Volkuur's Guidance Zealot Gloves (POE I)

Curious. The test spike penetrated the subject's flesh, but the chest wound was not as deep as expected. There is something here...

--Replica Soul Tether Cloth Belt (POE I)

Attempt #120: the prototype has finally achieved power similar to the original without breaking all the bones of the test subject. A rousing success.

--Replica Farrul's Fur Triumphant Lamellar (POE I)

Better... stronger... more vital... and then... failure. Always, failure. What key fundamental secret are we missing?

--Replica Loreweave Elegant Ringmail (POE I)

We could rival the gods with this power, if only we had the mitigating mechanisms to make it work. A jewel, a talisman, an armour... or the Font...

--Replica Nebulis Void Sceptre (POE I)

The type Delta test subjects could have escaped with the power offered by Prototype #15, but they suddenly chose to murder each other instead...

--Replica Hyrri's Truth Jade Amulet (POE I)

The Midnight Tinkerer's aid was invaluable during our brief alliance, but when we failed to make any progress on resurrection, he continued his search elsewhere...

--Replica Maloney's Mechanism Ornate Quiver (POE I)

Twelve test subjects were expended in the production of Prototype #800. Was it worth the expense? Only time will tell.

--Replica Pure Talent Viridian Jewel (POE I)

Suppression troop seven, the 'Glowing Faithful,' managed to fell the escaping test subject by timing their arrows between his explosive dashes.

--Replica Stampede Assassin's Boots (POE I)

ADMINISTRATOR QOTRA

Qotra meddles with forces she does not understand, and can never master.

--Kalandra, at the end of a Heist encounter (POE I)

Horrific experiments with corrupted flesh require careful management.

--Qotra's Regulator Sovereign Spiked Shield (POE I)

Researchers will refrain from scaring each other by firing ice spears while holding Prototype #141. Sooner or later, someone's going to lose an eye.

- Administrator Qotra

--Replica Cold Iron Point Ezomyte Dagger (POE I)

Outpost Twelve has been abandoned. On the bright side, I expect the plague of apparitions to serve as ample defence for the relics we left behind.

- Administrator Qotra

--Replica Bones of Ullr Silk Slippers (POE I)

As much as Prototype #20 hints at some deep alternate physics, we cannot afford to expend any more test subjects. Experiments halted.

- Administrator Qotra

--Replica Malachai's Artifice Unset Ring (POE I)

Researchers will please refrain from combining our prototypes with existing relics of power. The temptation is obvious, but the results can be... unpredictable.

- Administrator Qotra

--Replica Red Trail Titan Greaves (POE I)

Researchers will refrain from giving test subjects virtue gems which produce traps. We are still finding explosives in the vents months later.

- Administrator Qotra

--Replica Unstable Payload Cobalt Jewel (POE I)

Close to the original, and perhaps even more useful. However, close is not what we are looking for. Keep trying.

- Administrator Qotra

--Replica Victario's Charity Laminated Kite Shield (POE I)

Whatever these maps are, it is clear they are dangerous. Send in only test subjects, no guards or researchers.

- Administrator Qotra

--Replica Pillars of Arun Dunes Map (POE I)

Did nobody think to report that we had acquired some sort of free-floating memory? Cease testing and lock this away immediately!

- Administrator Qotra

--Replica Cortex Relic Chambers Map (POE I)

LEAD RESEARCHER KSARET

For personal defence, Prototype #444 is fantastic. It is one hundred percent effective seventy five percent of the time... once.

- Lead Researcher Ksaret

--Replica Mistwall Lacquered Buckler (POE I)

Does this jewel accomplish nothing? If only we could somehow master cold and turn it to our own ends...

- Lead Researcher Ksaret

--Replica Hotheaded Viridian Jewel (POE I)

Recommend extreme caution on any prototypes that can lead to a chain reaction of deaths. Lab Twelve has been lost to the flames.

- Lead Researcher Ksaret

--Replica Siegebreaker Heavy Belt (POE I)

The flames raced through Lab Five with incredible speed, but were extinguished just as quickly. This could have been much worse.

- Lead Researcher Ksaret

--Replica Emberwake Ruby Ring (POE I)

RESEARCHER GRAVEN

The cowardly thinker's greatest success is simply surviving.

--Graven's Secret Cloth Belt (POE I)

Test subject was able to survive the entire process simply by shouting epithets at the researcher. Researcher's feelings were slightly injured.

- Researcher Graven

--Replica Allure Vaal Claw (POE I)

This is what I've been trying to tell you. This prototype was different before. Now, it's always been this way!

- Researcher Graven

--Replica Perfect Form Zodiac Leather (POE I)

Prototype #56 was deemed safe, but judging by Administrator Qotra's new hustle and improved ability to micromanage us, I'm not so sure.

- Researcher Graven

--Replica Inya's Epiphany Arcanist Slippers (POE I)

The most terrifying split second of my life.

- Researcher Graven

--Replica Rumi's Concoction Granite Flask (POE I)

Once we armoured the test subject heavily enough to test Prototype #502, he proceeded to fight his way out. I don't know what we expected.

- Researcher Graven

--Replica Dreamfeather Eternal Sword (POE I)

Why is Prototype #67 never in the vault it should be? Either we're keeping faulty logs, or...

- Researcher Graven

--Replica Harvest Jasper Chopper (POE I)

I cannot fathom the mysteries of Prototype #16. It did nearly nothing until I brought it to [RESTRICTED]. It makes no sense!

- Researcher Graven

--Replica Bated Breath Chain Belt (POE I)

This is one riddle I can't solve.

- Researcher Graven

--Replica Paradoxica Vaal Rapier (POE I)

I believed I understood Prototype #112 quite fully, until a test subject with Azmeri ancestry donned it. I will be haunted by the results for the rest of my life.

- Researcher Graven

--Replica Forbidden Shako Great Crown (POE I)

Researcher Graven spent eleven hours suffering electrocution in the lab before he was found. Prototype #14 somehow kept him from dying.

--Replica Winterheart Gold Amulet (POE I)

Researcher Graven's request to wear Prototype #2998 in place of his standard lab attire is... granted.

- Lead Researcher Ksaret

--Replica Covenant Spidersilk Robe (POE I)

RESEARCHER ARN

The tortured thinker is made heavier by the weight of his guilt.

--Arn's Anguish Cloth Belt (POE I)

Beware. Prototype #91 is haunted by a strange miasma, an odour of evil. Nothing can shield the senses.

- Researcher Arn

--Replica Windripper Imperial Bow (POE I)

Ice and flame antagonized in the essence of a prototype. What once burned now chills the soul.

- Researcher Arn

--Replica Oro's Sacrifice Infernal Sword (POE I)

Are we mad for attempting to build an engine out of this? Looping cycles, power and pain...

- Researcher Arn

--Replica Tulfall Tornado Wand (POE I)

The form of this replica came to me in a troubled dream. I do not believe we should ever allow it to be used.

- Researcher Arn

--Replica Eternity Shroud Blood Raiment (POE I)

I feel altered when Administrator Qotra wears these gloves. Somehow, I find that disturbing.

- Researcher Arn

--Replica Grip of the Council Arcanist Gloves (POE I)

The theft of another's vitality is short-lived, but sweet. It calls to me, bidding me abandon all other pursuits.

- Researcher Arn

--Replica Soul Strike Spike-Point Arrow Quiver (POE I)

The night-gaunts, they fly, soaring about in darkness beyond the ken of mankind. I hear the silent whispers of their wings as they descend, for me, for me...

- Researcher Arn

--Replica Innsbury Edge Elder Sword (POE I)

Lord of Bone, Lord of Flesh, yet all that we can master turns to ash.

- Researcher Arn

--Replica Earendel's Embrace Grinning Fetish (POE I)

Eyes of black, three by three, staring ever darker into me...

- Researcher Arn

--Replica Shroud of the Lightless Carnal Armour (POE I)

RESEARCHER OLESYA

The cruel thinker finds glee in torture most precise.

--Olesya's Delight Cloth Belt (POE I)

Simply incredible. I caught an escaping test subject myself with swarms of burning skulls.
Delightful!

- Researcher Olesya

--Replica Midnight Bargain Engraved Wand (POE I)

There is something incredibly satisfying about impaling test subjects with Ethereal Knives. Perhaps it is the sound - the spell, the screams, or both.

- Researcher Olesya

--Replica Heartbreaker Royal Slean (POE I)

An absurdly vicious weapon in the hands of our test subjects. It seems to channel the desperate will to live. Intriguing.

- Researcher Olesya

--Replica Last Resort Nailed Fist (POE I)

You know what to do with this, don't you?- Researcher Graven

Kill test subjects for their vitality? - Researcher Olesya

That is not what he meant. - Researcher Arn

--Replica Blood Sacrifice Crimson Jewel (POE I)

DOCTOR BIRCUS

How did you manage to lodge arrows in every single test subject and researcher in Lab Three simultaneously?

- Doctor Bircus

--Replica Quill Rain Short Bow (POE I)

How did you manage to lodge arrows in every single test subject and researcher in Lab Three simultaneously... again?

- Doctor Bircus

--Replica Infractem Decimation Bow (POE I)

NON-REPLICA REPLICAS

Did we make this? Why do we have no record of it? We were warned that there would be consequences...

- Administrator Qotra

--Replica Dragonfang's Flight Onyx Amulet (POE I)

THE INCIDENT

I touched #2993, and I saw... how blind we've been. The visions weren't the future. They were the past! Our 'unforeseen consequences' have already been happening!

- Researcher Graven

--Replica Hinekora's Sight Onyx Amulet (POE I)

I stood upon the tower's edge, and saw that we had cracked the sky. There is nowhere we can run that our sins will not find us now.

- Researcher Arn, last recorded words

--Replica Badge of the Brotherhood Turquoise Amulet (POE I)

Yes, a catastrophic storm erupted, and yes, they screamed for me to stop the experiment... but you know how I am with screams.

- Researcher Olesya, on #2999 and the loss of Outpost Eight

--Replica Hyrri's Ire Zodiac Leather (POE I)

The storm... that lightning... I'd be dead if I hadn't... but it was cold. Ice cold! It's not what we think, and the plan won't work! Where's Arn?! I have to tell him!

- Researcher Graven, infirmary report

--Replica Heatshiver Leather Hood (POE I)

Nobody will listen to me, because I'm the only one that sees it. Nothing left to do now but drink until this world makes sense.

- Researcher Graven

--Replica Witchfire Brew Stibnite Flask (POE I)

The suppression troops have stopped responding to my orders. I'm no longer in charge, and I likely never truly was... I suspect they're already coming for us.

- Lead Researcher Ksaret, one hour post-Incident

--Replica Powerlessness Cobalt Jewel (POE I)

Release the type Delta test subjects. Unseal all prototype lockers. Arm yourself! I know that, as researchers, you've never had to fight before, but they're coming to kill us all. It's resist or die!

- Lead Researcher Ksaret, two hours post-Incident

--Replica Pacifism Viridian Jewel (POE I)

Our defenses are failing at Outpost One. We can't hold out much longer. All outposts, abandon your stations! Escape while you can!

- Lead Researcher Ksaret, three hours post-Incident

--Replica Fragility Crimson Jewel (POE I)